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Tom Scott

Tom Scott was raised in a musical family and has become one of the most iconic musicians in Los Angeles and around the world. He is a first-call studio musician, a T.V. and film composer, and his saxophone solos can be heard in hundreds of pop and jazz recordings.

Tom was interviewed via Zoom on April 1, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm extremely pleased to have Tom Scott with me here. It's morning in your time zone and I'm in the afternoon. And thank you so much for joining me.

TS: Oh it's my pleasure, Monk.

MR: The first question I have is rather an easy one: I've been reading through the list of your accomplishments in all the fields and I'm wondering is there possibly more than one Tom Scott?

TS: Well not that I know. Actually, seriously, there is still I believe, I believe he's still alive, a trumpet player, a session trumpet player in L.A. named Tom Scott. He was Thomas H., I'm Thomas W. So when I first started doing sessions in the late 60s, early 70s, there was some mix-up at the union over whose check was whose. So there was a bit of that but I haven't seen him in decades. I hope he is well. I don't know.

MR: You probably eventually made more on your checks than him. That's a guess of mine.

TS: Okay. I won't dispute that probably I guess.

MR: All right. When you were young, let's say early teens, did you have this feeling like music is definitely my path? You had a musical household. I'm wondering then when you got a little older did you have like a fall-back-on?

TS: Oh that's so funny you should say that. Because I tried that. I actually — well let me back up a little bit — when I went to my reunion, my high school reunion, I think it was my tenth reunion, people came up to me and said, you know, "You're the one who always knew what you wanted to do." And I hadn't really thought much about it but it is true that I was just music, music. You know I never really considered anything else, honestly. I didn't know, obviously when you're in junior high and high school you don't know how well you could do professionally, but my dad was a professional musician. I certainly had access to some quality music, both his record collection and my own father's music. He was a marvelous, marvelous composer.

MR: Is it true that he wrote [scats].

TS: No, no, no, "Twilight Zone?" No. He did do the underscore for several iconic episodes of "Twilight Zone," I think the most famous one is "A Stop at Willoughby" where a guy takes a train and he goes back to his hometown and he's an advertising exec or something and he was very unhappy with his life and he gets back to this town and realizes wait a minute, this is the way it looked when I was a kid. And so on. So yes, my father was a wonderful composer, in fact just a little aside, when he passed, you know in the middle part of the first decade of the 2000s, 2006 or 7, I was doing a session, a big, big orchestral session in which there was a portion of which John Williams was going to come and do a medley of famous Academy Award themes. And he came into the room, now I knew him, I had met him a couple of times, a few times here and there. But he came right up — I was at the end of the woodwind section. He walked into the room, saw me and came right up to me and kneeled down and said, "Tom, I just wanted you to know that when I was just a studio piano player in the 50s and considering whether I wanted to take the leap into film composing and television composing or not," he said, "one of my first assignments was under your father." And he said, "One of the reasons that I decided to continue pursuing a career in television and film music scoring was the fact that your father was so kind and encouraging to me." And he says, "I never forgot that." And I thought what nicer thing can one say about somebody's father. You know? And also I think if my dad had been a jerk would we have "Star Wars," "Superman," "Jaws." You know. "Indiana Jones," all these great themes. But anyway.

MR: That's some thought.

TS: But back to your question, so there was music all around me and I knew it's what I wanted to do from a very early age I guess. Now I had to — I went into the Air National Guard band based in Van Nuys, actually I did a year in street clothes because the Vietnam War was raging and there wasn't enough — they didn't even have uniforms or they couldn't send me to Basic Training, but I enlisted, it was a year before I even did Basic Training so I did a year in like street clothes rehearsing with this band two times a month — one weekend a month, Saturday and Sunday — and this went on for six years. But it kept me from having to worry about being drafted which of course, this was before the lottery system.

MR: I experienced that.

TS: Yeah okay, so you know. So if you either weren't having a full college load or could convince them that you were nuts, or gay or something that would — or had a serious physical disability, you were drafted. And of course you had the option of enlisting so that's what I ended up doing. I enlisted in this band. They actually recruited me, to be honest with you. So I did my Basic Training and came back and at that point of course I

music major, but I was so discouraged by the fact that there was no outlet for me to — I asked the professor when I signed up, "What are the chances of me putting together some kind of an ensemble?" I was already doing that. Okay? I already had a little band that I was writing for, kind of a Gil Evansy sort of an instrumentation, eight or nine piece. I forget what it was, band. So I proposed this to this guy, can I continue that kind of activity at an unused room at the school. And the guy looked at me and I swear to you he said, "Well maybe when you're a senior or a graduate student." Now I didn't take very kindly to that. I was not thrilled about the answer. So I did a half a year just doing general ed courses, I think philosophy and logic and a couple of things. And then summer came, because it was in the middle semester, and I thought you know what? Maybe I'll go to UCLA, never USC, I'll go to UCLA and enroll in maybe like philosophy or psychology or something, something to fall back on. And you know what happened? I went there to enroll, to register for the classes, to this giant campus where I'd be walking around endless I don't know miles, see it looked like miles to me, to take these courses. And I just thought you know what? This is not what I want to do. And of course I was starting to work so I had a little conference with my parents and also I remember sitting at Donte's jazz club with Chuck Berghofer, a great bass player, and asking, "Chuck, what do you think I should do?" And Chuck says, "Hey, if you want to do music you should do it." And I never looked back.

MR: Were there some aha moments, we might call them epiphanies now, but you mentioned something, we spoke briefly on the phone and you talked about a circumstance with Gerry Mulligan and Bob Brookmeyer.

TS: Oh yeah.

MR: Can you revisit that for me, because I found it really interesting.

TS: Absolutely. Well see I had met, well let me back up a little bit — I did two albums for Bob Thiele, Impulse Records, actually Oliver Nelson, God bless him, he provided the opportunity for Bob Thiele, the founder or at least — yeah I think he was the founder of Impulse Records, which of course was the label for all of John Coltrane's work until he passed, you know Eric Dolphy, Oliver Nelson, Charlie Mingus, just like a whole — the jazz cream of the crop, right? So this was such a privilege to be on this label. And Bob called me and said, listen, I've arranged for you to solo with the [extraneous buzz] — bye — arranged for me to solo on — or maybe I should go in another room. Anyway no, arranged for me to solo with the North Texas State Lab Band under the direction of a guy named Leon Breeden, who was a great guy. You may remember that name. He was fabulous. I loved him. So I flew a plane to Montreux, Switzerland where they were part of the Montreux Jazz Festival in 1970, and I played with the lab band. Gerry Mulligan

was there and I swear this is like, in fact I've got the picture here somewhere, oh yeah it's up there — if you could see that, it's a little hard to see let me see if I could —

MR: Yeah if you moved your screen a bit.

TS: Yeah that's me there and that's Gerry Mulligan. He invited me to sit in with him at Montreux. And I was just like oh my God, because he had been an idol of mine for — my first saxophone was the baritone sax.

MR: Were you playing tenor on this particular circumstance?

TS: Yes I was, yes, yes. It was a tenor. And so that was '70. So I believe the next year or I believe it was '71, I got a call from a record producer I knew, Stephan Goldman, who was also Roger Kellaway's producer, would I be interested — or, would I be interested, no that's not what he said, he said, "Gerry Mulligan wants you to play on his upcoming album" which ended up being called "Age of Steam." I said, "You've got to be kidding me, of course I'd be thrilled and honored." So I go to the first rehearsal, which is at Joe Porcaro's house, Joe Porcaro the drummer who, his sons all became great musicians, all of them. But we had this rehearsal and there I am, there's Mulligan and Brookmeyer and me. And so we started to play and you know how Mulligan and Brookmeyer had this great intuitive ability to play melody and countermelody, almost like a Bach duet where it's just beautiful, beautiful what they did, and of course it was all improvised. They just were so expert at you know creating melodies and the harmonies that go with them. So here I am, this third guy, and you know Mulligan says, "Join in with us." So I'm listening over there to what's going on and thinking okay I'll try to fill in the missing note of the triad. And we go for a little while and Brookmeyer says, "Stop, stop." He says, "Tom, listen, don't try to jump around and fill in notes." He says, "Pick an area, pick a register and stay within that register and we'll figure out the rest." Of course I was like, "Yes sir, Mr. Brookmeyer. Yes my jazz idol, I'll do whatever the hell you say." So that's what I did and of course it worked out well.

MR: That's so interesting because I've had that circumstance in giving lessons, like let's pick out whole notes and play — choose notes from the chord. And the student goes [scats].

TS: Right. Yeah, exactly. That's what I did.

MR: Well you can't buy that kind of lesson.

TS: You sure can't boy. And of course I've always had this thrill at coming up of always, you know, thank you Lord, being placed in situations with players who were more advanced than me. I mean frankly like that kicks your ass you know? When you have to step your game up to just be in the same room with these great musicians. That did marvelous things for my career and that particular experience was no exception.

MR: Did you remember feeling particularly nervous when the tape was rolling, and do you

TS: No. I'm not thinking about that at all. I'm thinking about the music and what the thing that I'm playing to, if it's a track, what the music dictates for me to play. I try to — I've always said you know if I'm doing a solo for somebody, or even my own records, I try to add the thing that will make that total music experience the best it can possibly be. And you can record it or not, that's — I don't care. And you know I've always felt that way. It doesn't matter.

MR: From your quote resume, it looks like you weren't just happy with being a saxophone player. I mean by that that you have film credits and conducting and arranging. Did that all develop about in the same time?

TS: Well roughly. I mean here's what happened. The first, if I remember this correctly, the first job that I was offered to write an episode of a television show was Universal. The music supervisor at Universal was a guy named Stanley Wilson, a friend of my father's, they had worked together, there are probably pictures, years ago. But I was sort of, you know, getting a reputation as this guy, this musical guy, and I had written a couple of tunes for Emil Richards, kind of odd time tunes and other things. I don't remember exactly how Stanley Wilson came to believe that I would be, that I would work as a T.V. composer but he believed it for whatever reason, and hired me to do an episode of a thing a series, it was called "The Bold Ones." And it was actually three separate series that kind of rotated every week. There was a doctor and a lawyer and a cop. Something like that. And I did one of them, I don't even remember which one it was now. But that was the beginning. So once you do a movie, or one show, that's a credit. And so now you have a credit and so that gives you some more, you know I don't want to say "clout," but it's certainly more credibility as a film and television composer, and then of course I befriended Dave Grusin. I played with him at Donte's. He played piano with the Howard Roberts Quintet. It was me and Howard and Dave, John Guerin, and Chuck Domanico. And it was a wonderful, wonderful band. And Dave was a great guy and I guess he recognized my abilities as well. So it was a show for Quinn Martin Productions. Quinn Martin Productions, back in those days, dominated prime time television shows.

MR: "The Fugitive."

TS: Sorry?

MR: "The Fugitive" and other.

TS: Yeah, "The Fugitive," "Cannon," "Streets of San Francisco," "Barnaby Jones," and more. But this was a show in 1969 I believe starring a then-unknown actor named Burt Reynolds. And it was called "Dan August." And Dave had written a great theme for this show, wonderful, wonderful theme. But he was doing feature films by that time so he couldn't do the weekly underscore for the show. So he told that music supervisor, another

also a damn good composer in his own right. But anyway Dave said why don't you get Tom, and so I was hired to do an episode of "Dan August" which I still remember the joy, the elation of standing on a podium with all the best musicians in Hollywood, you know I had Vince DeRosa on French horn, I think Ray Brown played bass, you know Bud Shank on woodwinds and just you know, and the best violin players in the business. Erno Neufeld I think was the great, great concertmaster at that time. And it was just, oh my gosh I can't tell you how good it felt to just hear this music coming back at you. It was a delight. I'll never forget it. So that's how it started.

MR: I want to say that you can't see the paperwork around me but I have a question and you just answered it.

TS: I did?

MR: Yes.

TS: There you go.

MR: That feeling of when you write an arrangement, no matter what the ensemble, especially the days before Finale and Sibelius, you're not positive exactly what it's going to sound like until people play it. And that feeling when it works is something else, and when it doesn't that's something else too.

TS: Well that's true. I didn't have the luxury of it not working. It pretty much had to work.

MR: How did you make sure as much as possible that it worked? Did you copy your own parts at that time and all that, like the detail of it to make sure it was right?

TS: Well no, no. But what I did do of course was, in those days as you well know, you had to write out your scores one part at a time. And I wrote transposed scores because as a reed player I couldn't stand to look at an alto saxophone part in concert. It just didn't look right to me. So I would compose and transpose as I was orchestrating. And — excuse me — they always — there was always a copyist on the staff so I never had to copy my own parts. But you know listen, here this is where my dad turned into — it was such a great help to me because he said, "Son don't compose at the piano. Compose in your head and then write it down and then use the piano to check and see what's right and maybe correct a voicing or something that," you know, but listen you do it enough times you get good at checking your work and going okay, and you know enough about the instruments of the orchestra and what sounds good to trust that it's going to sound right.

MR: And you had to learn how to work with a click track in your ear while you're conducting?

TS: Oh yeah.

MR: This segment is 18 seconds, etcetera?

TS: That's correct. It was, yeah, it was a whole separate science of how to make some hit, some chord or some thing in the music hit at exactly the right time where the gun is fired

mathematics involved. Once you decide what the right tempo is, what feels right, you can then determine what that is in terms of a metronome beat, which of course you have to translate to frames per second, a 12-frame click — well film runs at 24 frames per second. So a 24-frame click meant it went one click every second. A 12-frame click, half of that, would be a click every half a second. And then everything in between. So there was this book the Carroll Knudson book. And this guy should have gotten an award for patience because to mathematically calculate what — every page was a different click number and it was 12-1 in other words 12 and 1 sprocket hole; 12-2 — 12 frame and 2 sprocket holes, based on the film of course. So he calculated every beat from zero to, well as many calculations as a full page, you know, a computer page turned sideways would accommodate all the way to the last thing, which sometimes could go well into 8, 9, 10 minutes. So you know you've got to look at this book, where does the thing I want to hit fall? Okay? That's click number 37. All right well then you've got to manipulate your music in order to accommodate that hit. And that's the kind of thing, that was it. I mean sometimes it took as long — oh those chase scenes especially. Every one of these cop shows that I did always ended with a chase, usually a car chase or a foot chase, usually a car chase that would go, you know, two or sometimes three minutes. So you know oh God I've got to do the chase today. So you'd walk into your music studio, okay what is it to look at it or just try to remember — we couldn't really look at the video, we had already seen it once at the studio. All we had was a cue sheet of all the significant dialogue in a specific scene. So I'd go down and recall virtually, and everything's indicated. All significant action and dialogue is enumerated in this cue sheet. And then you know okay this happens there and then you do all this math. I mean that took half a day sometimes to just block out a big chase cue. Then, now you've got to go back to bar one and start writing the actual music.

MR: Regarding themes for the subsequent shows you did after "Dan August," music sometimes can convey emotions and sometimes music is just music. So was your task to read the description of what this show's going to be about, maybe about the characters you know, it's a cop but he's got marital trouble, he's got a young kid etcetera, and how much did the music you were trying to write reflect the story?

TS: Right. Great question. Well obviously — needless to say — music for films and television is a highly subjective matter. And so the good news for me, for me as a composer, is I get to see the film for the first time when it's basically complete except for the music. I cannot tell you how many times I've said I don't want to read the script, I don't want to see it halfway edited, because I want to see as close as you can get to the final product as possible before you show it to me. Now that's not always possible.

final edited, and of course I was just reminded of a — I don't know what it was, years ago, some movie, a movie of the week for television. So I'm busy writing and the director calls and he says, "Listen, Tom, we've made some cuts in this one scene but it won't affect you." Like hell it won't affect me. I didn't say that back, but that's what I'm thinking. Let me be the judge of whether it affects me or not because it could change everything. It could change the whole tone of it. But back to the question, I like to respond, as I say, when I'm seeing the final or closest to final version. I want to respond as the audience does. I'm the first like audience. So the music should, you know, should work kind of in terms of the audience's expectations. In other words is it just literally like a chase? Somebody chasing somebody? Or is there some psychologic — I love, by the way, scenes where there's some psychological drama. Not just what's going on action-wise on the screen but what's going on in someone's head. You know? They're about to murder somebody but they're not sure whether they want to do it or not, but they're having this normal conversation with the person who may be the victim, and you've got to play their thinking — "Oh I want to get this person" — but you have to do it, you know, that's really fun. You know the action scenes, you know I mean they've got to be done. But you asked about whether knowing the character's full story — it doesn't necessarily matter. It only matters in terms of what this scene is that we're looking at and what's going on there and do these character elements, do they play into this scene or not? And if they do then obviously you've got to take that into consideration.

MR: There's probably a musician's union scale and other organizations but the more you do, the more films you do can you start to demand or ask for better compensation?

TS: Well sure. I mean of course those of us who have done this work we all have agents whose job it is to negotiate such things. In television at the time I was doing the episodic stuff, 70s mostly, 70s and 80s, there was more or less a set fee for composing an episode of an hour dramatic series and so there wasn't a whole lot of negotiation going on. But as is the case with all negotiations your power is what you bring to the table, what strength do you bring to the negotiating table. If you're young and don't have any credits then you can't expect to demand very much. But obviously the more credits you accrue and particularly if you're associated with something that's a hit, that in a movie for example, that could give you more clout. Definitely.

MR: Did you in the early days of your writing actually go to see the movie? Go to the theater and see the movie that you just scored? Or had you had it by then?

TS: Yeah. I'm trying to remember if I did. I'm sure I did I just don't recall offhand, because of course when you look at a movie or score it from the cue sheets you kind of know it inside out so it's always good to know whether your music works with the movie and of

know occasionally a producer or director will go, "Listen this part is bothering me, can we fix it?" So I say, "Yes, give me ten minutes" and then I go in the orchestra and start dictating changes.

MR: Dictating changes to whom?

TS: To whatever musicians need to either stop doing what they're doing or do more.

MR: Okay. So now we're talking about, we just transitioned nicely to those studio cats, which you of course it's been a big part of your life. And your rise from let's say second alto to soloist I guess was because you did well at every stage?

TS: I guess. I mean life is a continuum and so it's, yes. That must have been it.

MR: Okay. So let's say we're going to pick — you had mentioned 1973 that there was a heck of a lot of things you did that year. And in that time period can you talk me through a typical day in the life of Tom Scott as far as perhaps getting a call to play a solo on someone's record. Can you tell me how that happens and then what it was like in the studio?

TS: You bet, sure. First of all your job if you're playing a solo on someone else's record obviously your job is to provide a service. You're a gun for hire so to speak and your job is to make them happy with whatever you do. So I look to the artist and/or the producer to give me any input that they want to. Sometimes it's in musical terms, many times it isn't. You know they want it to feel some more emotion here or in the case of Joni Mitchell she was a painter you know, and still is a painter. So she would say I don't know I want it more green over here. Now what the hell does that mean? Well it's my job to translate into music. Because Joni and many of the people I worked with were not formally educated in music. They didn't know how — Joni didn't even know, with all those beautiful chords that she used to make up on the piano and the guitar, she couldn't name one of them. She didn't care what they were called. She just liked the sound of them. And so it was my job to figure out what it is that I can add to this thing to make it better than when I walked in. So '73 I think in the very beginning of the year I did a tune with Carole King called "Jazzman." And I had not yet met Carole King. I think I met Lou Adler. Because I used to work, as many of us studio musicians did, at A&M Recording complex, which formerly was the Charlie Chaplin Studio many years ago in the silent era, and currently I think it's called the Jim Hensen Studio now. But there was a complex in the back of — one, two, three, four — four recording rooms and I used to be called to go in there all the time. And boy you could walk in there, it seemed like the center of the pop music universe back then because there'd be like Billy Preston over here and the Carpenters over here, and the Captain & Tenille, and John Lennon and Phil Spector in another room. Phil Spector was a — what a piece of work. But anyway it was just a

my previous trips into A&M. So I get a call, "Carole King would like you to play on her record." Okay, great. What instruments do I need? I need a tenor saxophone, okay, great. Because at the time you know I regularly was expected to have at my fingertips well my woodwind battery consisted of piccolo, flute, alto flute, bass flute, clarinet, bass clarinet, soprano — actually sopranino, soprano, alto, tenor, baritone and then recorders. I had a soprano recorder, a tenor recorder — yeah those two. So it was a lot of horns there to deal with. It was — for any of us woodwind players it was a good idea to have a big trunk behind your car because you needed the storage space. Anyway so I go in with Carole King and they're very sweet. They play me the tune and you know Lou Adler says, "Look just play what you feel." Okay. And that happens often. "Play what you feel."

MR: Did you even ask like well what key is it in? Or do you just wait until you put the headphones on and you —

TS: Yeah I found it pretty quickly what key it was in. Fortunately that one was in C, that one. So the people's key.

MR: Yes.

TS: Of course D for the tenor saxophone.

MR: Yeah sometimes you get those things like they're in the key of B and you're thinking oh my licks, I don't know if I can play those in C sharp.

TS: Well they're certainly not as easy to do, you just reminded me, recently I did a session for Robby Krieger of the Doors. He's still around. He's got a beautiful recording studio in Glendale, and I was called. He wanted me to play on something. In the middle of this tune it was sort of like a tribute to Bill — I don't know what the thing was, but anyway it was a jazz based lyric although it was a rock & roll tune for sure. But he said something about, "Well play 'Remember Bird'" or something like that, and then there's this section. And I'm supposed to — I have an alto saxophone and I'm supposed to play it. It's of course, he's a guitar player. What key do you think it's in? E. And I got through it but I told him, "Robbie listen, if you ever write any tribute to jazz again don't do it in E. Don't do it ever." If you go through the jazz fake books you won't find one tune in the key of E. I guarantee it.

MR: I'd like to talk about that later if we get back to it. But continue — so you go in the booth and Lou is there. Is Carole King there?

TS: Yes. They both were there. Let me just say at the outset they have remained to this day dear friends, they are both wonderful people. I actually did a podcast with Lou recently. I wanted to do one with Carole King but one of her daughters who is her manager, I called her and she said, "Listen, Tom, I don't think — the answer will be no I can tell you now. She just doesn't want to dwell on the past anymore." You know she's probably done a

plus she always lived a rather solitary life. She was in Idaho in a very, very remote part of Idaho. I'm not even sure they had indoor plumbing. It was really, really, you know in the woods kind of lifestyle. And just what a great lady. Lights up a room every time. So anyway, so I listened to the thing, they say play what you feel, I go out and I started playing. And I did a couple of takes but I just, I don't know we connected. I connected with this tune. And I did maybe two or three takes. They — actually they kept all of them and there's a couple of spots where you can hear me playing like two different solos simultaneously. Because they just — I don't know they liked the sound of the two things I played.

MR: That was on purpose then, not like bleed over from —

TS: No, no, no, not at all. Because they were all on separate tracks so there was no bleed at all. So that went well. That was a delightful session and you know with Carole King she had just come off the incredible success of "Tapestry" the album she did for Lou. In fact Lou was the one who said to her, "You know Carole, you ought to consider not just doing demos for other people but do your own record." And she was, you know maybe. He talked her into it and the result is "Tapestry."

MR: Did you get paid a predetermined fee for that particular session?

TS: Yes.

MR: Phil Woods told a story about how when he did "Just the Way You Are."

TS: Billy Joel, yeah.

MR: Yeah. He could have got a percentage of every record or something, every 45, as a soloist.

TS: He could've?

MR: He could have and he didn't know.

TS: Under what agreement is that? I've never of that.

MR: You've never heard of that?

TS: No.

MR: Well I'm going to have to consult Phil if I can.

TS: Oh well that's going to be tough.

MR: Yes it is. So but isn't there a thing in I don't know if it's the musician's union but as a soloist don't you get something beyond what let's say the bass player gets?

TS: Well in those days many of the A players were getting double scale, in other words, twice as much as was required by the contract between the musician's union and the recording companies. It was fairly common for the A players to get double scale. And there was a point at which I sometimes asked for and got triple scale. I don't think in '73 I had enough credits to demand that. I probably — well if you're the sole musician on a session

leader gets double scale. So you know I had yet to rack up a lot of recording credits. And I was just happy to be there, I knew I'd be paid fairly. I probably made double scale for that.

MR: And it's the type of session that you would have gone home and, "I want to tell somebody about this." If there's a question there it's did your constant studio work ever get to the point where it was like another day in the office?

TS: Well it was another day in the office in a literal sense, but what you're saying is did it get sort of ho-hum mundane. Never. Never. Because very simply you've got to show up with your A game every single time. You know? You're only as good as your last job. That's really true. And so, and plus I love my job. I look forward to being able to leave a session and go like you know, I'd go I gave the best I could to that particular musical challenge. That's what rewards me, other than the money of course. The money was great. But I would never consciously walk out of a session going aw I just phoned it in. I always tried to do the best I could.

MR: Were there sessions where you left after playing multiple solos and you didn't know what they were going to use and you might not find out what they were going to use until you were in your car listening?

TS: Every one, where I did multiple solos. I never knew what they were going to use. You've reminded me of a gentleman named Michael Masser. I can't remember whether he's still with us or not but he was a songwriter and record producer who called me one time, I didn't know him but he got my number and said, "Listen I'm producing a new young lady. I think she's a fantastic singer, I think she's going to be a big star. Her name is Whitney Houston. And I've written a bunch of songs for her and I'd like you to play on one." I said, "Fine." So I showed up to the studio. Michael was there, Whitney Houston was not, she had already laid down her vocal tracks so she didn't have to be there. And so it was a tune, it sort of reminded me, it definitely had a sort of 50s Doo-Wop kind of a feel. I mean it was a big production but basically was [scats] — that kind of a thing. So that's nice, you know, pleasant. And so I played fills behind her and Michael Masser he kept wanting, "Oh well let's do one more, do one more." So I don't know how many takes I did. It might have been over twenty. And finally I said, "Look, Michael, I don't — whatever I did, whatever the best thing I could possibly do is, you've got it there somewhere. I don't have any more to give to this thing. I'm done." And I just said, "I have to go now." So of course the record came out, it was a huge hit and I have some nice solos, things I'm very happy about. I think it enhanced the tune very well for what it was, you know tenor sax solo thing. About three months later, this is before the record came out the phone rings and I answer the phone, "Hello?" And a young lady says, "Is this

You played on my record." And I had to think a minute. "Oh yeah, yeah, right, hi, yes, how are you?" And she said, "I just wanted you to know that I really really loved the work you did on my record." And I said, "Well thank you, how nice of you to call, thanks for taking the time to do that." That was about the end of the conversation. And you know with all the things that happened to Whitney Houston since then, unfortunate things, tragic things obviously, I've always — whenever I hear anything said about her kind of negative I go, "You know what? I've got to tell you something." And look, I don't expect people to do what she did. That was way beyond the call of duty as far as I'm concerned. But she took the time to get my phone number, pick up the phone, call me and tell me that. That's a real kind gesture I think. And so I've always defended her saying look, and I always tell that story. And how many people do that? For whatever happened to her later in life she definitely was a kindhearted person, you know, in her heart.

MR: Oh thank you for sharing that. It helps me look at her differently also.

TS: Exactly.

MR: Was there competition, friendly or not, between the saxophone players especially because if any wind instrument is going to get a gig playing solos it's probably going to be a saxophone. So you have Ernie Watts and Plas Johnson and people at that level. Did you run into these other players and sort of like, "So what have you been doing lately? Who did you play with?"

TS: Not at all. It was not like that at all. No. No. No. Look we were a fraternity of very lucky musicians who managed to get into this very heady department of the music business. So we were thrilled to be there. I considered them fellow travelers, fellow musicians who I respected and admired. But you know also there were others at the time, in addition to Ernie and Plas, there was David Sanborn, there was Michael Brecker, there was Grover Washington. Now those guys pretty much — I'm sure there are other people I'm not mentioning but we were very prominently featured as saxophone soloists. And you know look, you can't take a gig away from somebody. I mean producers and artists like who they like and they're going to call them. And at the time of course, unlike today, there was plenty of work for everybody to, you know, to survive and flourish. So it didn't feel like that competition. In fact they were my buddies, especially David and Michael and Grover became a dear friend. Just great guys you know. Look, we had so much in common, our love for the saxophone and music and jazz. So you know what are you going to do, pretend you don't like somebody like that or you're in competition with them? It wasn't a competition that way.

Part II

MR: On the, talk about Steely Dan for a bit. On the one side of the Aja LP you have Tom Scott on "Black Cow," you have Pete Christlieb on "Deacon Blues" and you've got Wayne Shorter. You couldn't get anybody good, could they?

TS: I know. Pete Christlieb is another one I should have included him in that list of people I mentioned. Pete I met when I was about 14 years old. There was a youth band initiated by Ollie Mitchell, who was a great trumpet player. He was a studio trumpet player back in those days and they had a rehearsal facility and I wanted to join the band so badly. So I walk in the door and then there's this tall, I don't know I was 14 maybe he was 16 I don't know, maybe like that. And he's playing this fantastic solo. And I go oh my God who is that? If I can ever play anything like him I will have made it. And of course it was Pete Christlieb. And we became dear friends. And I used him on any T.V. or movie session I could get him on. I wanted him there because that beautiful sound and of course he was also a classic curmudgeon. He always had some very funny things to say, sometimes about the business, sometimes about who knows what. But he was — you know I used to love to fill my sessions with, what did I call them, you know loudmouth curmudgeons and just, you know bullshitters. Because they also were so entertaining between the music I mean you know it felt in a way like a wonderful party, a gathering of just great individuals and obviously very talented individuals.

MR: At what point in Steely Dan recordings did you get the tunes that you were going to add horn section parts to?

TS: Right. Well I had met Walter Becker, one half of Steely Dan of course, through a mutual friend. And so I got a call from him saying, "Look we are working on our new album" [Steely Dan] and I wondered if you could come down and listen and maybe write some horn arrangements." I was like great. Because Steely Dan was already, you know, a very hot property. So I walked into Village Recorders in West Los Angeles and I met Donald Fagan and their producer — I can't think of his name right now. Donald and Walter led the proceedings. So they played me the tunes. They told me, here's what they said: "We want a lot of horns" you know he says, "but we don't want any like high screaming trumpet parts." I said okay, I won't write high screaming trumpet parts. But we ended up with, we agreed on a section that was I think four saxes, two trombones, two trumpets I think that's what it turned out to be. So they gave me a reel to reel tape in those days of course of the tunes except for Aja of course, which is the tune that has the Wayne Shorter solo and didn't require any horn sweetening. So I go home and I began to write. And we had set up sessions, I heard the band, which included let's see I think Pete couldn't do it because they were night sessions and he was doing "The Tonight Show" at the time. But

I got Plas Johnson; Jackie Kelso, another wonderful saxophone player; Bill Perkins, another saxophone player.

MR: And Jim Horn.

TS: Jim Horn was on it too? Oh my gosh okay.

MR: According to my notes here.

TS: I'm sure it's right if you say so. And Chuck Findley and somebody else on trumpet, I don't remember who. And Slyde Hyde and somebody else, maybe Lew McCreary on trumpet — on trombone I mean.

MR: Yes. And Plas Johnson also.

TS: Yeah Plas of course. So it was supposed to be, I think we did it, we had four sessions, evening sessions planned to do all — was it eight tunes? Seven tunes? Eight tunes? I'm not sure. And I had written you know, they had given me their master rhythm parts which the rhythm section had used to make their tracks. And if I may get technical for a second, the tune "Deacon Blues" started out with a chord which was just a triad. It was a E minor, you could call it an E minor chord with a G in the bass. G in the bottom E and B. That's what the rhythm section played, the very first chord. Now that chord kept coming up later at the point where I was supposed to come in with horns. So you know I've got all these horns, I'm not just going to play three notes. That would be ridiculous. So I pulled what I used to refer to as an Oliver Nelson because Oliver was my hero, my mentor. And he loved those very close juicy voicings where the juicy notes, you know the extended parts of the chord are not up here but they're right in the middle. So I took that first chord, that E minor G bass, and turned it into a G 13 chord. So it was G on the bottom and then E, the E below middle C, and then F – A – B – and E on top. So it's like a G 13. With the E part, the 13th part in octaves.

MR: Was it a, speaking of being technical, was it a C sharp or was it a C?

TS: There was no C in it at all, it was a G chord.

MR: Oh it was a G chord. Okay.

TS: G – E – F – A – B – E.

MR: I got it.

TS: Right? So that's and it kind of went on that way with this tight voicings. And I didn't know, man, I had no idea how they would react but they liked it. And in fact with the exception of one tune, and that was "Deacon Blues" everything went as written. Talk about good fortune smiling on Tom. But the only tune that I had to change was a tune in which they had inserted something after they gave me these tapes, and the thing they had inserted was Pete Christlieb's solo on "Deacon Blues." I had written something else in there and I had to re-do that and make I guess a background or I forget what I did. But in

MR: Especially when you hear the long version and it's fading out.

TS: Right. Yes, the fade licks. I know. Well Pete you know, Pete was fantastic, I mean is fantastic. He always was and always will be just a tremendously under-rated talent. You know what I mean?

MR: You know there's something about that song I love, it's lyrically and Fagan sings "I'll learn to work the saxophone." And I often wondered did he first write, "I'll learn to play the saxophone."

TS: That's a great question.

MR: It's just that word is so hip.

TS: I don't know. You know listen they obviously, whether it was Becker or Fagan or both of them together, they really had a flair for interesting lyrics which evoked, you know they weren't, they sort of rode the line between what half expected and half unexpected. That was one of the unexpected turns. I think they prided themselves in that lyrically.

MR: They were well known for sort of a revolving door of guitar players coming in and out and I wonder did you ever have a circumstance where you played a solo on a Steely Dan song and when it came out it was somebody else?

TS: No.

MR: I'm glad then.

TS: In fact I used to say I consider myself very lucky that I made it through that week without any changes because you know with the exception of "Deacon Blues" because as I used to say there's bodies of drummers, bass players and guitarists strewn out the door and down Santa Monica Boulevard of those who tried and failed. And you know I never understood that because obviously they were looking for something and they kept trying until they got it. But the thing they were looking for was never clear to me. How different would it have been with Bernard Purdie as opposed to say Steve Gadd or Rick Marotta or you know, it would have been a little different but how did that know that in front? You know, I think you have to try a bunch of — I suppose you try a bunch of players and then maybe you know what? Maybe they decided you know what? We had it with the first drummer. So in other words the last one to play on it didn't necessarily end up on the record.

MR: How true.

TS: That's true. I don't know that for a fact. I did a podcast with Walter Becker, I mean with Donald Fagan, I should have asked him that. Crap. I blew it.

MR: Here's a quote from one of your colleagues about those years. And he said, "This isn't playing it's craft. L.A. is an incredible place for craft. Your soul is not usually nurtured."

TS: Well I don't agree with that.

TS: No. No. My soul was nurtured every day.

MR: Okay.

TS: I love my work. I mean look there were sessions I did where I didn't necessarily like — there were pop sessions we did. The ones that come to mind are the ones that we used to do with a guy named Wes Farrell, who for a brief time was married to one of Sinatra's daughters, Tina. And he was a real, I don't know, Mike Melvoin called him a schtarker. I guess that means sort of a poser. He was a poser. He always dressed very elegantly and had the talk — he was a fast-talking New Yorker, you know, like that, and he produced all the Partridge Family records and David Cassidy. And there were a bunch of them. And so we, the horn section, which was at the time I think it was me, Chuck Findley, Ollie Mitchell, who I mentioned before, Slyde Hyde and Lew McCrury. We would go into do the horn overdubs and Mike Melvoin wrote these horn charts, most of them. And sometimes Jim Hughart. So even though the tune was kind of I don't know, dumb, or mundane, you know it didn't matter because we were there to play the best damn horn section you've ever heard in your life. So we took our part very seriously within what we were doing. We didn't know how far in the mix it was going to be or whether it was going to be there at all. We didn't really care, it wasn't our job. Our job was to go in there and play with one another, which we took great joy in doing, and whatever the music is man, we'll just nail it. So that was you know soul gratifying, just to do that, regardless of the artist.

MR: Did you ever get to the point, I'll preface this by I was able to do an interview with Oliver Nelson Junior.

TS: Right.

MR: And he said that his father was afraid to turn down work, that he felt if he started turning down jobs that he, you know, would sink down on the list and consequently he just kept doing it until he couldn't to it anymore. Did you ever feel like okay I did four sessions today, maybe I should not keep doing that?

TS: Well rarely did I ever, I don't think I ever did four sessions. The rhythm section guys did. They could work from morning until late at night. That was very, very rare with me. But there were times, in the words of Earl, the great drummer.

MR: Earl Palmer?

TS: Earl Palmer. He said, "You know sometimes it comes to a point when you're in a session and it just keeps going and going and you go 'I don't want to make any more money, I just want to go home.'" And were there some moments like that? Sure. But in the main it was fun to be there. It was really great. As I say, I didn't work those kind of early in the morning all the way 'til late at night. I can't think of one. There may have been a couple

MR: If you wanted to take a two week vacation in those days was that a little risky?

TS: Well the thing is you've got to get to a point where you're comfortable in the fact that you have a career and you will get called, even if you take off a couple of weeks, which I did. You know me and my first wife took vacations. We went to Hawaii a couple of times and it never bothered me. Because there seemed to be — the calls seemed to keep coming in. And back to Oliver, I think Oliver was wrong in the sense that as Lou Adler said to me once, "Tom, sometimes it's a good idea to keep yourself a little bit of a mystery about you. You become more interesting when you're not taking something for a while. Like ooh he's got bigger plans or he's got a, just an image of what he's going to accept. Because Oliver could have done more motion pictures for example, but doing that show "The Six Million Dollar Man" every single week and insisting on composing and orchestrating everything, they were on a much quicker schedule than I ever was. It was like once a week man, there was a show. So we had like seven days to write and entire score for that show. And he, you know he did drink and I think complicated by alcohol and working until he was just exhausted. He went home after a session, morning session for "The Six Million Dollar Man" and laid down and passed away. That's what happened.

MR: And you mentioned almost in passing that he could have passed on some of the work, like the orchestration to other people.

TS: Yes. He could have but he just didn't want to. Again I think it's that thing that I've got to do everything, I've got to just be the Mr. Wonderful in every possible way as a composer. And you don't have to. You know there are very successful composers who had orchestrators throughout their careers.

MR: Before I forget I wanted to tell you one of my first early exposures to you was "Spontaneous Combustion."

TS: Oh my Lord.

MR: Yeah. I had the record.

TS: That was a very long time ago.

MR: Yes.

TS: That was a record that featured much of the L.A. studio guys and I think did we have a singer? I can't remember. Anyway it was like Tom and John Bayler who were singers and John was an arranger also, and gosh Mike Melvoin, Jim Horn on saxophone, again, Ollie Mitchell, Chuck Findley on trumpets, Slyde Hyde. It may have been, I can't remember who the other trombone player was. Maybe George Bohannon. And who played drums, John Guerin played drums, Max Bennett on bass, I think maybe Larry Carlton on guitar. It was really the cream of the crop rhythm section and horns in those

MR: Before we get to — we have to talk about your own solo recordings. What has happened to the business? I think of all the jazz graduates coming out of the schools every year and many of them must head to L.A. Is there any — what's the business like for them to head to these days?

TS: Not great. Not great. I would put it to you this way: there is far more qualified musicians than there is work to keep them busy. And that's a problem, a problem we didn't have back then. But we have it now. The sessions are few and far between as we've gone to much computer-generated music and you know the advent of music that's basically free off the Internet, or purchasable for a pittance. There's no interest in doing a record for profit. It's just not profitable anymore. So you know it's just the opportunities just aren't out there.

MR: So your timing was good.

TS: Thank you Lord, yes.

MR: When you got ready to do a solo recording what came first, the band? The material? Or the agreement from a record company?

TS: Well my very first album was for Bob Thiele of Impulse. And he, I figured out that he thought he could make me into kind of a pop saxophone player. I think maybe he thought he could get a pop instrumental hit from my album, my first album. It was called "Honeysuckle Breeze" which was an original tune composed by Ian Freebairn-Smith, one of the arrangers. I basically just walked in and played the charts that were put in front of me. So I guess I had signed the contract with Impulse, a typical record deal at that time. I think it was probably a deal for three or four albums, one per year, and of course the record company had the option every year to pick-up or drop me, and a royalty rate which was pathetically small by today's standards. But on the other hand you know that was a different era. The record companies put a lot of money into marketing, promotion and advertising. And of course they did all of that at a certain amount of expense to them and they had big buildings with employees. I mean they had a big nut to pay. So I'm sympathetic on the one hand, but I didn't expect to make money off my record. I hoped I would but again I think that probably the record contract came first, and then the session, the recording itself. As I say there was a stand with arrangements on it and I just played them with all these wonderful, again sort of 60s Wrecking Crew musicians. Carol Kaye on bass, Mike Melvoin on keyboards, Emil Richards on percussion, Jim Gordon on drums, and Glen Campbell on rhythm guitar. He was not yet a star and was doing rhythm guitar sessions as a session player, and I think Dennis Budimir was the other — I mean these were all the guys that were busy studio players in the pop music scene at the time. So it wasn't a jazz record, although I played some licks that I suppose you could classify

MR: Well there was a time, especially in the 50s and 60s where you could have an instrumental hit, you know "Cast Your Fate to the Wind" and "Stranger on the Shore."

TS: Right. Acker Bilk.

MR: Yes.

TS: Vince Guaraldi. I remember them all well.

MR: But when you got to the point where you had a reputation and you were doing solo recordings, I'm wondering how much thought did you give to fitting into what niche? Was it going to be jazz-rock, was it — or maybe this didn't even occur to you. Maybe you were just composing music and looking for tunes that you liked?

TS: Pretty much the latter. I was in New York, I can't remember why, but I got to see Bob Thiele in his office at Impulse Records at the time, and it was time to do another, a second album. And he said, "Tom what do you want to do?" And I said, "I want to do a jazz album with my quartet" which at the time was Mike Lang on piano, Chuck Domanico on bass and John Guerin on drums. And so he said, "Cool." So back in Los Angeles I walked into United Recording Studio. Bob was in the booth and his engineer, a guy named Eddie Bracken, I'll never forget him 'cause boy I don't know whether he was on stimulants or what he was doing but he was like at that board and he — and in those days it was like rotary pots, it went like this — round knobs that you turned for volume up and down. And he'd sit there at that board and he'd — oh man, the guy's going to have a heart attack. I think eventually he did. But anyway so I went in there with my quartet and made what I considered to be a jazz album. I mean it was a jazz album. And there's a funny story connected with that actually which involves the shooting of the cover. The cover was determined by Bob — well the title of the album was determined to be Rural Still Life which was the opening track of the album, a tune that Mike Lang had written. So I got a call from the photographer one day, he says, "Listen, Bob Thiele has asked me to shoot your cover and he told me it's 'Rural Still Life'" so he says, "I know this place out in the north San Fernando Valley where they have horses and cabins and sort of a western little community." So he said, "Let's go out there, bring your band and we'll find a place to shoot the cover with the band." I said, "Great." So we found this cabin, this unoccupied cabin, and we posed in front of it and took the picture which became the cover of the record "Rural Still Life." About six months later that cabin and that surrounding area became the home of the Charles Manson family. It was the Spahn Movie Ranch.

MR: Wow.

TS: And we got out of there just in time I always like to say.

MR: So that probably increases the value of that LP if you can find it.

MR: Which is your favorite — I'll rephrase. Do you think of yourself as a saxophone player as my alto is more of my jazz horn, my tenor is more of my pop horn? Is that not relevant?

TS: It's a good question. I think in my mind — I mean look I play pop music on alto and tenor and jazz on alto and tenor. I think if you were to ask me to pick the instrument that I feel most comfortable about playing jazz on it's probably the alto. And of course Cannonball Adderley especially has been an incredible influence on my playing and continues to be to this day. Oh look at him, oh man. What a player.

MR: I had that ready because you and I share that. I think he's the tops. He just —

TS: Absolutely. Absolutely. And you know back when I was — '57, '58, '59 of course, when all those great Miles Davis Sextet albums were recorded I used to — I have told people, I've told kids when I teach to try to explain the difference between those three soloists: Miles Davis, John Coltrane and Cannonball Adderley. You know Miles, and these are generalizations of course, but you know it's more or less true, that Miles was very sophisticated and played — you know he held back a lot. He'd go [scats]. And you'd just wait for the note, what's he going to do next? Actually you create a great deal of drama by doing that, you just draw people in by playing less. Then there's Coltrane, who was on this search. They used to call it "sheets of sound." But to me it sounded like he was on this incredible, unbelievable, fantastic search you know, and tons of notes and man it was like amazing. And then Cannonball comes on and he's like, "Hey great day, isn't it?" [scats] You know? Just happy. Just real happy. And it's that attitude that I always related to because that was really me more than the other people, although as I say, I admired both Miles and Coltrane. I have all their records. And between those three people — Miles, Coltrane and Cannonball — those are the three biggest record, collections, parts of my record collection, those three.

MR: And he was so effective as a band leader and a speaker. I mean he just was so hip, he'd stand up there and, I got to see him a number of times and I just was so sucked into him.

TS: His vibe. Absolutely. Well he was a teacher in Florida as I understand. But what a player, what a marvelous player. I still, you know the one that kills me, it's an album called "Nippon Soul." And there's a tune called "Easy to Love" the Cole Porter tune "Easy to Love." He plays at a breakneck speed and he plays the most phenomenal solo that goes on and on, he never repeats himself. But it's just, you can not believe the creativity and genius displayed in that solo. It's unbelievable.

MR: It's like that recording of "Spectacular" — it's like spectacular. But I always — we can get off this momentarily but it's interesting that one of his biggest hits was of course "Mercy Mercy" which he does not solo on . I like to tell my students the greatest note ever played on the saxophone is when he goes [scats].

MR: It hits you. I see that hip looking microphone there, is that what you use for your podcast?

TS: No it's not actually. I have this little machine here. I'm an artist for Zoom audio products. I use this little thing which is the pod track. I think it's P-4 pod track I think it's called. And it's amazing. You know the microphone goes in the back, headphones go in the front, and it goes USB into the computer so whoever's on the computer it records them on one track and me on another. It records separate tracks inside this little machine.

MR: Yeah I listened to a couple of them including Donald Fagan. I wonder how you prepare for your sessions?

TS: My podcast sessions?

MR: Yes.

TS: Well I do research. I do all the research I can come up with and then give it all the information I can garnish. I try to ask questions that I'd want to ask, questions that I think people would want to know about, and just I list them, you know I list them and kind of put them in some kind of chronology. I always ask people — but the overall picture of my podcast is that the life of a successful person in whatever field has sort of three parts. There's the part where they're young, growing up, and then something happens that triggers their thought about doing this thing that they ended up doing so successfully, if it was someone they saw, someone they knew, how that happened. You know there's like a flashpoint. And then the second part is that bridge. How do you get from there to ultimate success. And that of course always is a very interesting part of anyone's life. And then of course discussing their success. But I don't consider myself like an interviewer on "The Tonight Show" where I want to know your latest outings. Because I think people want and need to know the story of these successful people, and that nobody was born successful. There's a lot of sweat, work, effort, and you know and disappointments sometimes in getting there. And you know I want people to know that if they want to do something bad enough and are willing to put that at the forefront of their efforts, you know, they'd be amazed at what they can achieve and not take defeat as anything but a challenge to be overcome.

MR: Nice words of wisdom. We've been at this for some time and I very much appreciate your time. What makes, or made in the past, producers call you rather than all those other terrific saxophonists in your mind? What was it about Tom Scott's sound and approach that got you all those calls?

TS: You know what? I honestly don't know. You'd have to ask them. You know I mean I was one of the guys and I'm going to guess now but I would suspect there's something that I did prior to them calling me that they liked and they wanted on their project.

MR: Did you think rhythmically first when you're — I don't know if that's a good question or

TS: No.

MR: So the rhythm of your solos is obviously very important.

TS: Yeah it is but I'm not analyzing it from a brain standpoint. I'm reacting emotionally. And sometimes I'll have them play, before I've gone into the studio to do the solo I'll have them play that eight or sixteen bar section for me and I'll listen to it and try to get a vision, you know, what I'm going to play and the feel of it. And sometimes some ideas will come to me, you know, just in thinking about it. Okay so I've got the general feel. Now I'm going to go out there — if you ask me to play eight different tracks you're going to get eight different solos but I know that you'll find there are similarities between all of them because I sort of mold a general direction and it's going to show up in all those tracks somewhere.

MR: What's on your docket these days?

TS: Well right now of course I'm doing some gratis work. Of course I've got my podcast, I've got a radio show on KJZZ which is the Southern California jazz station, I've got a weekly jazz show there called "Hang Time with Tom Scott." I'm doing of course I've done a lot of — I got on Tik Tok at the recommendation of the guy who is now my producer in Connecticut actually, and so I've got a whole series of Tik Toks where they're sort of two part Tik Toks. The first one is where I play that portion of a record where I've soloed. And I'll take that, I bought a green screen and so I will mime that solo in this green screen and then send that to my guy in Connecticut and he puts the album, the cover of the album I'm playing, if it's Carole King "Jazzman" or Paul McCartney and Wings, whatever it is, in the background. That's one Tik Tok and then the second one is where I talk, "Yes I did play the solo on Carole King's 'Jazzman' and here's how it happened." And I tell the story of going to the studio and like that. So I must have probably thirty pairs of Tik Toks. I'm @TomScottJazzman if anybody wants to look. And so there's that, the radio show, I'm also — well I've got, I'm still working on my upcoming, I'm doing an album here, probably this summer. And it's going to be, I hate to say L.A. Express, because it could end up being the New York Express. We're still debating whether to do it — I'm going to New York in July to teach as I have done two or three years back at the Summer Jazz Program. This year oddly enough I'll be teaching audio engineering which of course I have done but I've done it from the standpoint of a musician. There's actually three of us: me, and then there's a guy who actually is a fulltime audio engineer. He is the engineer for "Saturday Night Live" among other things. But he's I think on staff at NYU where this is taking place. And the third guy is like a hip hop guy, a loop guy. So between the three of us they'll get a real full picture of what it's like sitting at a board, and of course I am proud to say that I am a Hawaiian

is a wonderful ukulele player in Hawaii and we did a whole album with her, some jazz tunes, some folky, folkish kind of tunes, even one classical tune. We did the Faure "Pavane" kind of in the style of a Bill Evans with a symphony orchestra record. And except for her playing and a couple of jazz soloists that I got on the record, Arturo Sandoval, Ray Parker and Michael McDonald did a whole bunch of vocals on one of his tunes. But the rest was all me: drums and bass and keyboards and strings and everything, and engineered it. And for that, so I do know how a board works. And of course back in the days when I was doing my own records regularly my engineer Hank Cicalo, well there were other engineers but primarily he's the one that comes to mind because I did L.A. Express, New York Connection, all that stuff with him. He would, on a 24-track machine he's got 24 faders there. So he would take the front 16, which was the drums, the rhythm section basically, and I would take the back 8 which would be all the overdubs, the saxes, woodwinds, anything else. So we would mix the thing, manually of course in those days, there was no automatic floating faders, well there were but we didn't have them. And so we did it all manually. And so I do know the board, and so I can bring some wisdom to that area I hope.

MR: Let me just wrap up, I forgot to ask about Paul McCartney, who over the years definitely knew what he wanted. I think of the "Penny Lane" trumpet solo and apparently how he vocalized it and had George Martin write it down.

TS: Right.

MR: When you played on that Wings track, did he tell you what to play?

TS: Well you know if you'll give me just a second I can read you from a quote from Paul McCartney himself. Let me see if you've got it here. Do you edit this or is it just like one continuous piece?

MR: We can edit the little downtime, sure.

[1:27:12]

TS: All right give me a second here.

TS: Yes, okay. So in a subsequent article after the record came out in an issue of *Rolling Stone*, Paul said, and I quote: "We were in Los Angeles. 'Listen to What the Man Said' was one of the songs we had high hopes for. But when we did the backing track we thought it didn't really get it together at all. Someone said Tom Scott lived very near so we said give him a ring. He turned up in half an hour. He put his headphones on and started playing along casually. Meanwhile the engineer was recording it. No one could believe it. He had all this feeling on his first take." And in fact I thought I was just playing along to learn the tune. My eyes were closed and I had no idea that I was being recorded. In fact when the thing ended I looked up and everyone was applauding in the

unconscious take. So I said, “Let me do one more.” Because now I know the tune. Of course you can well imagine the take that went on the final record, it’s that one that was just pure feel.

MR: My face is hurting from smiling so much, Tom. That’s just marvelous. Well I want to thank you again for your time.

TS: No problem.

MR: This has been like sort of a nice fantasy of mine and you made it come true.

TS: Well glad to do it. Happy to do it. Your questions are great and I hope it serves the purpose.

MR: Great. And welcome — I hope that you projects go well and that you keep doing what you’re doing, and I’m glad you didn’t fall back on the fall-back-on.

TS: No. No I didn’t. I sure didn’t. All right. Thanks a lot.

MR: I’ll just pause this, and, all right.